The Four Building Blocks to a Balanced Dog

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Introduction

Bringing a dog into your life is about more than just teaching a few tricks or keeping them busy—it's about building a strong bond with a calm, confident, and well-adjusted companion. That kind of relationship is built on a foundation that *you* put in place.

This booklet introduces you to the **Four Building Blocks to a Balanced Dog**—a simple, powerful framework designed to help you understand and support your dog's true needs. Instead of focusing only on obedience, you'll discover how health, lifestyle, clarity, and skills work together to shape your dog's behaviour, wellbeing and your life together.

Inside, you'll learn:

- Why each building block matters (and why missing one creates problems)
- How to fulfil your dog's physical and mental needs
- How to build a clear communication system so your dog understands you
- How to build an unbreakable bond
- Practical ways to use play, routines, and training to improve daily life
- Real-world examples you can start using straight away—whether you have a playful puppy or a seasoned adult

Whether you're just starting out or want to deepen your bond, this guide will show you how to create real balance and harmony at home—and set your dog up for a lifetime of success.

Block 1: Health – The Foundation of Everything

Before you can expect your dog to learn, behave, or thrive, they must first feel good in their body. This block is the non-negotiable starting point—without physical wellbeing, no amount of training, play, or structure will stick.

A dog in pain, discomfort, or poor health can't be expected to focus, cooperate, or feel calm. Health must come first—always.

Key Elements of Canine Health

*1. **Diet***

- Feed a species-appropriate, balanced diet that fuels your dog's body and mind.
- Puppies need extra support for growth and development.
- A mix of raw, air or freeze-dried food should be used—**aim for nutrient density and minimal processing**.
- High-quality kibble can be mixed with the above for financial or practical reasons, if needed.
- Poor nutrition often shows up as behavioural issues, poor coat and severe illness, years down the track. Though an inappropriate diet can affect reactivity and other behaviours in the short term also.

*2. **Rest & Recovery***

- Dogs need much more sleep than people realise, depending on age and breed—**12–20 hours a day**.
- Overstimulated dogs become hyperactive and mouthy, not just tired.
- Provide **structured down time**, and don't underestimate the importance of calm spaces and alone time for nervous system recovery.

*3. **Pain Management***

- Always rule out pain if your dog's behaviour changes or they resist handling or training.
- Dogs hide pain well—watch for subtle signs: reluctance to jump, changes in posture, irritability, or licking a body part.
- Address both **acute (injury)** and **chronic (arthritis, gut issues, structural problems)** pain.

*4. **Vet Check-Ups***

- Regular health assessments are essential—even for young or seemingly healthy dogs.
- Get baseline bloodwork done early in life for comparison later.
- Early detection of issues can prevent long-term suffering or expensive interventions.

*5. **Supplements (if needed)***

- Not every dog needs supplements, but they can support joints, skin, digestion, and cognition when chosen wisely.

- Consider:
    - Omega-3s for inflammation and coat health
    - Probiotics for gut support
    - Joint supplements for active or ageing dogs

Why You Can't Skip This Block

- A dog in pain won't respond to leash pressure, play, or commands without distress.
- Poor sleep leads to over-arousal, short fuse, and erratic behaviour.
- Medical issues often *look like* behaviour problems—but they're not.

When something seems "off," start by checking physical health. Don't train over pain.

Block 2: Lifestyle – Fulfilling Your Dog's Mind

Once physical health is in check, your dog needs a **healthy mind and purpose**. Without this, dogs become restless, anxious, or difficult to manage—not because they're a problem, but because they're having a problem.

Key Elements of Canine Lifestyle

*1. **Purpose & Fulfilment***

- Every breed—and every individual dog—has natural drives, whether it's to chase, herd, hunt, guard, retrieve, or problem-solve.
- While we can't always provide the *real* job (e.g. sheep to herd, animals to hunt), we can **mimic it through thoughtful play and training**:
    - Herding types enjoy movement-based control games
    - Hunting breeds love scent work or tracking games
    - Guarding breeds thrive on controlled protection-style play
    - Most breeds enjoy a game of **fetch or tug**
- When we find what truly gets your dog ticking—and provide it regularly—you unlock their **natural motivation**.

*2. **Freedom & Expression***

- Dogs need time to run, sniff, chew, and just *be a dog*.
- Provide outlets (sniff walks, off leash running, chewing stations) that give your dog freedom, **without sacrificing safety**.
- Suppression creates frustration—**structured expression creates balance**.

*3. **Play***

- Play is how dogs' bond, learn, and regulate emotion.
- Prioritise **interactive human play** like tug, chase, and fetch.
- Occasionally allow well-managed play with other dogs, but not daily—**you should remain their main source of fun and fulfilment**.

*4. **Scent Work***

- Scenting is a biological need for all dogs—not just hounds.
- Simple games like "find it," scatter feeding, or intro-level scent work build confidence and calmness.

Why This Block Matters

- Mental fulfilment is not optional—it's essential.
- Dogs with unmet lifestyle needs often show signs like:
    - Excessive barking
    - Destruction
    - Escaping or chasing
    - Over-excitement or reactivity
- A fulfilled dog is more focused, more cooperative, and more peaceful in daily life.

Find what drives your dog—and use it later to build clarity and skills.

Fulfil the Drive Without the Job

You don't need sheep, birds, or criminals to satisfy your dog's instincts.
You just need smart substitutions.

Drive Type	Fulfilment Examples
Herding (e.g. Border Collie, Kelpie)	Flirt pole games, herding-style obedience (directional work, body pressure), pattern games, movement control play
Hunting / Retrieving (e.g. Spaniels, Labradors)	"Find it" scent games, tracking, fetch and delivery games, hide-and-seek
Guarding / Protection (e.g. Rottweiler, GSD)	Tug games with rules, obedience with control under pressure, protection sports, bite pillows (with care)
Sighthounds (e.g. Greyhound, Whippet)	Chase games with flirt poles or fast-moving toys, sprint-and-rest style play
Terriers / Digging breeds	Dig pits, flirt pole games, tug, puzzle feeders, rag games
Companion / Low-drive dogs	Food enrichment, gentle scent games, casual structured walks, soft engagement games (tug, treat tosses)

Match the activity to the dog's DNA—and you'll unlock the best version of them.

Block 3: Clarity – Understanding & Communication

Even the healthiest, most fulfilled dog will struggle to fit into our lives without **clarity**. Dogs need to understand what is expected of them, what their boundaries are, and how to interpret our feedback.

Confusion creates anxiety. Clarity creates confidence.

What Clarity Really Means

Clarity isn't about rigid control—it's about consistent, meaningful communication. When your dog knows what words and tools mean, they feel more secure, cooperative, and calm.

A clear system reduces stress, builds trust, and eliminates guesswork.

1. **The 4 Windows of Opportunity**

Dogs move through 3 natural "windows" or states of being and one that we need to create. Teaching your dog to *enter and exit* each one smoothly creates emotional balance, better behaviour, and a deeper bond.

Window/ Command	Purpose	Definition
Ready	Engagement	Interactive play with you. Builds relationship, drive, and focus.
Free	Exploration	Off-duty time to sniff, wander, or just be a dog. Self-directed decompression and fun.
Settle	Calmness	Low arousal, calm relaxation. Teaches patience and emotional control. Must be non-negotiable.
Work	Obedience	Structured skills, commands, and focused effort. Clear expectations, non-negotiable follow-through.

Teaching your puppy these states—and how to switch between them—is one of the most valuable things you'll ever do.

This becomes the **framework for daily life**, not just a training concept.

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2. **Markers Build Meaning**

Words like "yes," "wrong," and "no" are not just instructions—they're communication packages, giving the dog multiple bits of info in one precise moment.

- **"Yes"** – Correct! Leave your position and take your reward from handler.
- **"Get it"** – Correct! Leave your position and take your reward over there.
- **"Wrong"** – Try something else, no big deal. No reward for that behaviour.

- **"No"** – That's over. Stop the behaviour now and forever. Intolerable outcome is coming.

These markers create predictability, reduce frustration, and make communication faster and clearer.

Markers are best taught during the Ready window—when your dog is playful and open to learning.

How to Use Markers: Click! Mark the Moment

Markers ("yes", "wrong" or "no") are like pressing the shutter button on a camera: They take a snapshot of the *exact* moment / behaviour your dog does something you want to strengthen or weaken.

- **Yes** – Taking a photo of the behaviour that your dog did right. That behaviour will be remembered and repeated over time because it is followed by a reward.
- **Wrong** – A gentle click of the camera showing your dog that this moment won't lead to rewards. No big deal just try something else.
- **No** – A clear picture of what behaviour is unacceptable and should not ever be repeated. The dog understands this as we follow "no" with something undesirable to the dog which they want to avoid. *This should always be done fairly.*

Why it works:

Dogs live in the moment. Markers "freeze" the exact second your dog makes a choice. This crystal-clear feedback helps your dog understand what gets reinforced and what doesn't. Making your communication more efficient, fairer and less emotional.

Think of yourself as your dog's photographer—capturing the moments you want to see more of!

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3. **The Leash Is Communication, Not Restraint**

The leash is an extension of your relationship—not just a tool for control.

- Teach your dog how to *respond* to leash pressure, not just tolerate it.
- Use soft guidance, not jerking or dragging.
- Pressure should feel like conversation, not conflict.

When used clearly and fairly, the leash becomes a calm, reliable bridge between you and your dog.

Why Clarity Is Foundational

- Dogs without clarity guess—and usually guess wrong.
- Inconsistent communication creates confusion, stress, and disobedience.
- Clear systems allow your dog to relax, focus, and make better choices.

Clarity isn't about perfection—it's about predictability. Dogs thrive when they know what things mean.

Block 4: Skills – Obedience That Holds Up in Real Life

With health, lifestyle, and clarity in place, we can now focus on **skills**—the structured obedience behaviours that help your dog function calmly and confidently in everyday life.

Skills are the *visible layer* of training, but they only work when the other foundations are solid. If your dog is unwell, under-stimulated, or confused about what's expected of them, obedience will always be shaky.

Skills give your dog the ability to *live well* in our human world—and give you the tools to guide them calmly through it.

What Skills Really Mean

Skills aren't just about tricks or control. They're about building your dog's ability to:

- **Focus under pressure**
- **Pause when needed**
- **Move with you calmly and safely**
- **Respond to direction anywhere, anytime**

Obedience shouldn't feel like a power struggle—it should feel like a **shared language**.

When trained properly, these skills increase freedom, reduce conflict, and make life more enjoyable for everyone involved.

Core Life Skills Every Dog Should Learn

Command / Concept	Purpose
Sit / Down	Stillness and focus
Stay / Wait	Patience and self-control
Recall (Come)	Freedom and safety
Loose Lead Walking (Let's go)	Calm navigation through the world
Place	Boundaries and relaxation
Leave It	Impulse control and safety
Out	Impulse control, play
Thresholds	Respect for space and exits
Middle	Engagement, safety, confidence

These are real-life skills—not tricks. They reduce stress, increase trust, and make daily life smoother.

Teaching Through Play, Not Pressure

- Most skills are best taught through **play** and **luring**, during the **Ready** window.
- As your dog matures, the expectations increase—but the training remains **fair, consistent, and fun**.
- Skills should be **proofed** in every window—*Free, Settle, Work, and during Ready*—so your dog doesn't only listen in perfect conditions.

The Work Window Needs Ongoing Work

- Obedience is not a one-time achievement—it's a skillset that needs **ongoing maintenance and generalisation**.
- Dogs must learn to perform behaviours in different environments, levels of distraction, and states of arousal.

- The **Work window** must be revisited regularly and adjusted as the dog's needs and challenges evolve.

A dog that can "sit" in your kitchen but not at the café doesn't have the skill—they have a trick.

True obedience isn't what the dog does in training—it's what they can do in real life.

Wrapping Up: The Four Building Blocks of Balance

When all four blocks—**Health**, **Lifestyle**, **Clarity**, and **Skills**—are working together, you don't just have a trained dog.

You have a calm, confident companion who:

- Feels good in their body
- Feels fulfilled in their mind
- Understands how to live with you
- Can follow your lead in the real world

This is how balance is built—and how harmony between humans and dogs is truly achieved.

Build the blocks. Live the balance.